

Country Profile: New Zealand

- Number of groups in country: 4
- Plurality religion: Non-religious
- Official language: None
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Europeans

Historical Background

New Zealand is a constitutional monarchy and unitary parliamentary democracy, with the monarch of the United Kingdom as head of state. In 1947, it attained full legislative independence from the United Kingdom by the Statute of Westminster.¹ Although the islands had been settled by Māori voyagers from eastern Polynesia since the mid-13th century, the modern state and its political institutions are shaped by the history of European settler colonialism.

Groups

- **Europeans** in New Zealand comprise the core group of the state. They are descendants of British and other European settlers who began arriving in large numbers in the 19th century and continued through the 20th century.² Today, forming a distinct racialized group, they constitute around 68% of the population,³ a notable decrease from 94% in the 1940s.⁴ They remain the largest and politically dominant group in New Zealand and speak English, the principal language of the country.⁵ Religiously, about one-quarter are Roman Catholic, one-third are Anglican, and the remaining half are non-religious.⁶ This group is also sometimes referred to as “Pākehā”, the Māori word for New Zealanders of European descent.⁷

¹ Statute of Westminster, 1947.

² Royal, 2005.

³ Stats NZ, 2023a.

⁴ Census and Statistics Department, 1951.

⁵ Stenhouse, 2018.

⁶ Bormann et al., 2021.

⁷ Black, 2010.

- **Asians** in New Zealand comprise a nested racialized group. The largest three subgroups include **Chinese**, **Indian** and **Filipino**, although the term encompasses individuals identifying with ethnicities from different Asian countries.⁸ Today, they comprise around 11% of the national population, a significant increase from around 0.1% in the 1940s.⁹ This was largely driven by immigration policy shifts in the mid-1980s,¹⁰ although Chinese and Indians had arrived as early as the 19th century.¹¹ Today, most Asians in New Zealand speak English alongside their mother tongues, predominantly Mandarin for Chinese communities, Hindi for Indian communities, and Tagalog for Filipino communities.¹² Religiously, Indians follow Hinduism, Filipinos mostly profess Roman Catholicism, and approximately half of Asians, including Chinese, identify as non-religious.¹³
- **Māoris** are the Indigenous racialized group in New Zealand, comprising approximately 14% of the population, up from 6–7% during 1940s and 1950s, a change which resulted from higher self-identification.¹⁴ They settled in New Zealand from the 11th century, and historically were attached to animist beliefs.¹⁵ However, Colonial influence caused a shift toward Christianity, creating religious movements like Ringatu and Pai Mārire.¹⁶ Today, the majority are non-religious, with smaller minorities following Roman Catholicism and Anglicanism.¹⁷ They speak Māori, also known as Te Reo Māori, which is considered endangered, as many use English in their daily life.¹⁸ Māori activists have pursued greater territorial and cultural autonomy since 1962, when they established the Māori Congress.¹⁹ A more radical Māori protest movement began in the 1970s with calls for the return of lands and access to natural resources.²⁰ While the Māori have not held a dominant political position among ruling elites, their cultural practices are

⁸ Stats NZ, 2023b.

⁹ Ho, 2015; Stats NZ, 2018.

¹⁰ Ho, 2015, 95.

¹¹ Ip, 1995; Leckie, 2007.

¹² Ho, 2015.

¹³ Stats NZ, 2018.

¹⁴ Stats NZ, 2018.

¹⁵ Minority Rights, 2018; National Library of New Zealand, n.d.

¹⁶ National Library of New Zealand, n.d.

¹⁷ Stats NZ, 2018.

¹⁸ Ethnologue, 2025.

¹⁹ Sambanis et al., 2017.

²⁰ Hewitt and Cheetham, 2000, 185.

constitutionally recognized. The Treaty of Waitangi, signed between Māori chiefs and the British Crown in 1840 is considered New Zealand's founding document.²¹

- **Pacific Islanders** are a racialized group in New Zealand and comprise approximately 7% of the population, a marked increase from 2% in the 1970s.²² Substantial immigration began in the 1950s and peaked during the 1960s and early 1970s, due to New Zealand's labour demands and programs for family reunification.²³ Sāmoan and Tongan remain widely spoken in their respective communities, and about one-fifth of Cook Islanders in New Zealand speak Rarotongan.²⁴ Approximately less than one-half are Protestant, about a third are non-religious, and almost a quarter are Roman Catholic.²⁵ They are spatially concentrated in the North Island, predominantly in Auckland.²⁶

State Profile

Official Language

New Zealand's constitution does not designate an official language. However, the Māori Language Act of 1987 declared Māori an official language and granted the right to use it in legal proceedings.²⁷ New Zealand Sign Language has held the same status since 2006.²⁸ English, though never formally declared, functions as the country's *de facto* language of government and daily public life.²⁹

Official Religion

New Zealand does not recognize an official religion.

Education Policies

Education in New Zealand is organized by the Ministry of Education.³⁰ Compulsory education in New Zealand consists of primary education (grades 1–6), intermediate

²¹ Minority Rights, 2018.

²² Pool and Jackson, 2013; Salman, 2023.

²³ Spoonley, 2018.

²⁴ New Zealand Curriculum, 2024.

²⁵ Stats NZ, 2018.

²⁶ Amituanai-Toloa, 2015, 259.

²⁷ Māori Language Act, 1987.

²⁸ New Zealand Sign Language Act, 2006.

²⁹ Bardsley, 2013.

³⁰ Scholaro, 2025.

education (grades 7–8), and secondary education (grades 9–13), though schools vary in how they implement these stages.³¹ Both private and public schools must meet the national education standards.

While there has been an official stance against **segregation** since the colonial period, the New Zealand public education system effectively segregated Māori students from the majority population until the late 1960s.³² From 1867, Māori schools were administered separately by the Department of Education and operated with an assimilationist focus, emphasizing English language instruction. While not legally required to attend separate schools, Māori were typically educated separately.³³ Following the 1962 Currie Commission, which recommended full integration, the Education Amendment Act of 1968 enabled the transfer of the remaining Māori schools to regional education boards in 1969.³⁴

Affirmative action policies to support Māori and Pacific Islanders' access to higher education have been in place in New Zealand since 1972, when a dedicated university admissions pathway was introduced to increase Māori and Pacific Islanders' representation in the health sector.³⁵ Although New Zealand has no single overarching affirmative action law, universities are empowered by the Education Act of 1989 to implement such measures.³⁶ Starting in 1939, a Māori teacher training quota was introduced, which enabled over 400 Māori to enter the teaching profession before the policy was abolished in 1969.³⁷

Language Education Policies

English is the primary language of instruction in New Zealand's education system. While not constitutionally declared an official language, it is used universally across public schooling.

The **Māori** language was declared an official language of New Zealand under the Māori Language Act of 1987. This granted official status to the Māori language and marked the

³¹ Scholaro, 2025.

³² Stephenson, 2006.

³³ Stephenson, 2006.

³⁴ Stephenson, 2006.

³⁵ Stewart, 2003.

³⁶ Queen's University, 2025.

³⁷ Walker, 1986.

start of formal state support for Māori language education.³⁸ Māori as a language of instruction was formally recognized under the 1989 Education Act, which provided for the establishment of state schools using Māori as the primary medium of instruction.³⁹

Mandarin Chinese was introduced as an optional class in the 1980s and later formally integrated into the national curriculum in 1995.⁴⁰ Participation was limited until 2014, when the launch of the Asian Language Learning in Schools (ALLiS) program, which expanded education in this language, provided a major boost. By 2015, Mandarin had become the most widely taught additional language in primary and lower secondary schools.⁴¹

Among Pacific languages, **Samoan** was added to the national curriculum in 1996 as both a language class and a medium of instruction in some bilingual primary schools.⁴² **Tongan** and **Rarotongan** were included in the 2007 curriculum and are taught as language classes.⁴³ **Tagalog** is not formally included in the curriculum but has been offered in at least one private school.⁴⁴ **Hindi** is neither part of the curriculum nor is it offered in schools.

Religious Education Policies

Under Section 44 of the Education Act of 1964, primary public schooling in New Zealand is required to be secular.⁴⁵ Schools may offer religious education—defined as the academic, non-confessional study of religion—within the curriculum, provided it remains non-compulsory and neutral in tone. Religious instruction, understood as confessional teaching of a particular faith, is permitted only under certain conditions, including approval by the school board. It must occur outside of official teaching hours, during a time when the school is formally considered “closed.”⁴⁶ The New Zealand Bill of Rights Act of 1990 reinforced this framework by requiring that participation remain voluntary and by prohibiting discrimination against those who do not follow, or follow another religion.⁴⁷

³⁸ Māori Language Act, 1987.

³⁹ Education Act, 1989.

⁴⁰ Chinese in the New Zealand Curriculum, 1995.

⁴¹ Wang, 2021.

⁴² Samoan in the New Zealand Curriculum, 1996; Amituanai-Tolosa, 2015, 259.

⁴³ East, as cited in Collins, 2018; New Zealand Curriculum, 2007.

⁴⁴ Business Mirror, 2019.

⁴⁵ Education Act, 1964.

⁴⁶ Education Act, 1964; Human Rights Commission, 2009.

⁴⁷ New Zealand Bill of Rights Act, 1990.

Teaching in secondary schools does not have to be explicitly secular as per Section 27 of the Education Act of 1964.⁴⁸

Private and “integrated” schools operate under a separate legal regime. The Private Schools Conditional Integration Act of 1975 allowed religious schools—primarily Catholic—to receive state funding while retaining their “special character”. These schools are not required to “close” for religious instruction and may include faith-based content during regular teaching hours.⁴⁹ New Zealand’s legal framework draws a distinction: public schools must separate religious instruction from official teaching and ensure full opt-in protections, while private and integrated schools may embed religious content more directly into school life.

Bans and Restrictions

Maori. While there were never any formal or explicit bans or restrictions, Māori was actively discouraged in schools—sometimes through physical punishment—and sidelined in media and public life, particularly from the early 1900s to the 1970s. Urban migration and assimilation policies like “pepper-potting” further disrupted Māori-speaking communities.⁵⁰ The discrimination of the Maori language in public life ended in 1972 with the Maori language petition.

Constitutions and Laws

The first constitutional act in force for New Zealand in the study period was adopted in 1852. Lacking a singular written constitution, New Zealand’s constitutional structure is uncoded and dispersed across statutes, conventions, and legal principles. Nevertheless, these acts form the legal foundation of parliamentary sovereignty and legal principles. The 1852 Constitution Act did not declare an official language, nor did it include any provisions on religion. Article **71** made explicit reference to Māori as **“the aboriginal or native inhabitants of New Zealand.” This category does not include Pacific Islanders.** Article 71 also permitted Māori to maintain their “laws, customs, and usages” for their self-governance, provided “they are not repugnant to the general

⁴⁸ Education Act, 1964.

⁴⁹ Private Schools Conditional Integration Act, 1975.

⁵⁰ Ka'ai-Mahuta, 2011.

principles of humanity.”⁵¹ The 1947 Amendment to this act introduced a modification, replacing the word “native” with “Māori”.⁵²

As a part of the broader constitutional framework, the 1975 Treaty of Waitangi Act explicitly mentions Māori in Article 2: “Māori means a person of the Māori race of New Zealand; and includes any descendant of such a person.”⁵³ The next official Constitution Act came in 1986 and repealed many articles from its predecessor, but did not mention religious freedom, religion, language, or any other group.⁵⁴

The 1990 Bill of Rights Act fits into this constitutional framework. It did not change the status of the Māori, nor did it explicitly declare an official language,⁵⁵ however Māori was granted official status by the 1987 Māori Language Act, which is not considered constitutional.⁵⁶ Article 13 of the Bill of Rights declares, “Everyone has the right to freedom of thought, conscience, religion, and belief, including the right to adopt and to hold opinions without interference.” Article 15 protects the right of religious expression.⁵⁷ There is no explicit declaration of New Zealand’s secularity in any of the constitutions.

Citizenship Laws

New Zealand granted **unconditional birthright citizenship** (*jus soli*) until a major reform in **2005**. The **Citizenship Amendment Act of 2005** introduced a conditional *jus soli* regime: children born in New Zealand only acquire citizenship at birth if **at least one parent is, or was, a citizen or permanent resident of New Zealand, the Cook Islands, Niue, or Tokelau**.⁵⁸ Foreign nationals may acquire New Zealand citizenship through naturalization, regulated by Sections 8 and 9 of the Citizenship Act of 1977.⁵⁹ No special provisions or preferential pathways currently exist for any particular foreign group.

⁵¹ Constitution Act of New Zealand, 1852.

⁵² Māori Purposes Act, 1947.

⁵³ Treaty of Waitangi Act, 1975.

⁵⁴ Constitution Act, 1986.

⁵⁵ New Zealand Bill of Rights 1990.

⁵⁶ Māori Language Act, 1987.

⁵⁷ New Zealand Bill of Rights, 1990.

⁵⁸ McMillan and Hood, 2016; Citizenship Amendment Act, 2005.

⁵⁹ McMillan and Hood, 2016, 14.

Chinese people in New Zealand were excluded from applying for naturalization from 1908 until 1951.⁶⁰ In 1982, the Citizenship (Western Samoa) Act was passed to deny citizenship to Western Samoans born between 1924 and 1949.⁶¹

National Anthem(s)

New Zealand has two official national anthems: “God Save the King”, adopted in 1840, and “God Defend New Zealand”, adopted in 1977 following a public petition.⁶² The latter is the anthem most commonly performed at public events and serves as the primary expression of national identity. It is frequently performed with the first verse sung in te reo Māori, followed by English. This anthem reflects a strong invocation of divine protection and national unity. It includes multiple references to religion, asking God to “defend our free land,” and to “bless this place”. The anthem also contains references to the national territory, notably in its lines, “May our mountains ever be/ Freedom’s ramparts on the sea.” Notably, the lines “Men of every creed and race/ gather here before Thy face,” affirms an inclusive vision of citizenship and national belonging. The anthem’s themes also emphasize national pride (“make her praises heard afar”), a defensive military posture (“put our enemies to flight”), and political values such as peace and justice (“peace, not war, shall be our boast” and “let our cause be just and right”). Despite the co-official status of “God Save the King”, it is now rarely sung outside of royal occasions, with “God Defend New Zealand” serving as the country’s functional anthem.⁶³

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⁶⁰ Green, 2005.

⁶¹ Citizenship (Western Samoa) Act, 1982.

⁶² Nationalanthem.info, n.d.

⁶³ Nationalanthem.info, n.d

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